

Lasting Change Comes From Within

If you listen closely, we will answer some difficult questions in this session. For some of you, we may even create questions you had never thought to ask.

I have often wondered why one person seems to have every natural ability while another does not. One person is attractive, can sing, and has money. Another seems to carry almost no visible ability. Then someone like Einstein comes along and discovers theories most of us did not even know existed.

People can sing like no one else, run faster than anyone else, or display extraordinary natural gifts. Yet the first man, Adam, was perfect. After the fall, spiritual death entered, and the gifts and capacities of humanity were scattered through the human race.

But God is no respecter of persons. What made me equal with you is not my first birth, but my second birth. Through the new birth, we all receive access to the Word of God and the Holy Ghost. Everything needed for transformation into what Jesus says we are has been made available.

Some of us may start far behind the gate, but we can still catch up and finish our course.

Permanent change comes from within. A person may have been affected by failure through the first birth, but from the second birth on, God has given everything needed to finish as a winner.

There is one thing required: we must learn to tap into the ability of the new creation within us and yield that inner man to the Holy Spirit.

The Holy Spirit baptized us within our human spirit because He is Spirit, and He came to teach our spirit one-on-one. What religion can boast that its Teacher lives within the student for a lifetime?

If you receive His instruction, power will be generated in your spirit and move into the soul realm where the character flaws lie. Transformation can become so complete that God can make out of you anything Jesus said you are.

Most believers do not understand how to tap into the ability of the inner man. We could not study the basics of prayer without studying this.

Jesus said:

| A good man out of the good treasure of the heart bringeth forth good things...

The unregenerated or regenerated spirit is the powerhouse. Science has tried to label this operation as the subconscious mind. They recognize it has capabilities far beyond the natural brain and can record enormous amounts of information. Under hypnosis, people can recall things from early childhood that their natural mind had forgotten.

All permanent change comes from that inner operation. If you listen to the Holy Spirit within, transformation takes place first in the heart or spirit, then it overpowers character flaws and causes you to succeed.

In nearly eighteen years of ministry, I have watched church people come and go. They know Jesus, yet many share the same failures as sinners. They carry the same weights, suffer the same diseases, and are taken out by the same patterns.

We do have a covenant. To say otherwise would be to deny the Word of God.

Faith people rightly teach that we are spirit, soul, and body, and that the born-again spirit is made the righteousness of God in Christ and seated in heavenly places. But some go further and say the human spirit already knows everything and only the soul needs renewing.

If that were true in the way they claim, then every time the soul tried to sabotage us, the all-knowing spirit would rise up and cancel it. But most believers still fail. So the born-again spirit has received the new nature, but it must be taught.

The Holy Spirit has come to teach the human spirit until transformation becomes strong enough that the soul can no longer sabotage the breakthrough.

One day as I drove through Tulsa, the Lord spoke to me about a house. He said, "Do you know that the inside of the man who lives in that house is an exact picture of the outside of that house?"

I could only see the outside, but He was saying the man's circumstances reflected what was operating inside him.

If your spirit were like a camera and we could take a picture of it, the picture would match the circumstances around you. If I suddenly gave a man a million dollars, the outside might look different for a while. But unless something changed inside, the exterior would eventually conform again to the interior.

That is why the Holy Ghost came. He went to live where the problem is. He teaches and transforms from within.

Thank God for teachers who teach mysteries the Holy Spirit has shown them from the Word. But if people are taught error, the Holy Spirit can be handcuffed by what they refuse to hear. Churches can be full of people who speak with tongues and yet remain in bondage because legalism or false doctrine has imprisoned the Spirit's ability to teach them.

When I speak with tongues, the Holy Spirit creates a supernatural language inside my spirit. My mind is unfruitful, but the Spirit empowers me to pray mysteries before the Father.

Those mysteries are not for God's benefit. You are not going to teach Him something He did not already know. They are for your benefit.

Praying in tongues is like any other form of prayer: it is designed to be answered. When you pray in the Holy Ghost through your authority on the earth as part of the body of Christ, you release the Father to answer that prayer. The answer comes as the Holy Spirit teaches your spirit the mysteries you prayed and are ready to yield to.

This is why edification is not merely presence or anointing. Presence is when the Holy Spirit makes you aware that He is with you. Edification is the process by which the Holy Spirit transforms your life to the Word.

For years I wrestled with the question of how God could use people powerfully while deep flaws remained in their lives.

I saw men operate in miracles while serious sin or torment worked in them. I counseled ministries that had once been used mightily and then disintegrated. I spent many hours with John Wesley Fletcher, trying to teach him how to gain ascendancy over the flesh and walk out of devastation. He would bury his face and cry, "I can't help it."

I had been in A. A. Allen's meetings and saw miracle after miracle. I watched people get out of wheelchairs. Yet reports later said he struggled deeply. I saw other ministers used by God and yet tormented by sin.

The holiness camp often says God cannot use such a person. But I had seen God use them. That does not mean God condones sin. He hates sin wherever He meets it. It means a person can know how to yield in one area of the spirit while still not knowing how to get help in another area of the flesh.

Anyone whose heart runs toward God is a candidate for God to change. But condemnation without transformation leaves people miserable, wanting to serve God but unable to get free.

Second Corinthians 7:1 says:

Let us cleanse ourselves from all filthiness of the flesh and spirit...

There is sin of the flesh, which we recognize easily: carnality, lusts, and outward sins. A person may fall deeper and deceive himself into thinking he is getting by with it.

But there is also filthiness or sin of the spirit, and it is unbelief. It is refusing to yield to the Holy Spirit's purpose in coming to guide you into all truth.

Jesus said the Spirit would guide us into all truth, and the Word is truth. The Holy Spirit baptized your spirit because your spirit is the one He came to tutor.

John said:

The anointing which ye have received of him abideth in you... and teacheth you of all things.

That does not do away with teachers, pastors, or evangelists. It removes their ability to seduce you away from truth if you are yielding to the Teacher within.

The Holy Ghost has been given to teach the baby believer who comes into the kingdom with a clean slate. That is why the devil has attacked the baptism in the Holy Ghost and especially tongues. Tongues is one of your direct accesses to God, and it causes transformation and wisdom to rise in you.

After a year or so of praying, verses open up and you wonder why everyone does not see them.

The Spirit needs your authority in the earth. Without a preacher, how shall they hear? Jesus is the Head, but He works through His body. When you pray in tongues, you lend Him your spirit as a point of authority. He creates the language and prays through you. All He needs is the authority you yield, and He will change your life.

The power of God does not flow through the soul realm. It flows through the spirit.

When the disciples could not cast out the devil, Jesus said it was because of unbelief. The devil was not monitoring the tone of their voices to see whether they sounded afraid. God was monitoring unbelief in the spirit, the kind that ties His hands.

Exterior holiness alone does not produce power. A person may live clean outwardly, yet when he lays hands on the sick, nothing happens. Another man may be deeply flawed, yet in the area of his spirit where he knows the power of God, he can empty wheelchairs. That does not excuse sin. Many such men were eventually destroyed by the flesh.

If you deceive yourself into thinking you are getting by with sin, you are not. There is an answer, and God demands holiness. If you refuse the answer, God must eventually step back, and the devil will drag the sin out of the closet and put it on display.

Praying in the Holy Ghost begins transformation first at the spiritual level. It builds your born-again spirit, fills it with the Word, and strengthens faith. Then the Holy Spirit reaches into the soul and deals with character flaws.

Many people pray against fruit while the root remains. They pray for disease to leave, but it comes back because the root was not healed. They get torment off a person, but it grows back because the root remains.

Through the Spirit we mortify the deeds of the body because those deeds have spiritual roots. As you keep praying in the Holy Ghost, the Spirit keeps edifying, transforming, and putting to death what causes failure.

Meditate the Word day and night. Supply the Holy Ghost with all the information He can use to bring change. Paul received revelation directly from the Holy Spirit and recorded it in the epistles. Now the Word is complete, and the Holy Spirit takes the written Word and causes it to come alive inside us.

When false teachers come, He sounds the alarm. When I move toward the flesh, He warns me to crucify the root before it goes deeper and destroys a long, fruitful ministry.

Some of you have been deeply abused and mistreated. My mother was a periodic alcoholic. Different men came home drunk, played father for a month or two, and disappeared. Intimidation, fear, and rejection developed deeply in me.

I could disappear from home for a week and nobody checked to see whether I had died. Things like that can go deep and camouflage a person.

But the Holy Spirit, working with the incorruptible seed and the new nature, began clipping those roots. How did I know? Because peace made it to my soul.

Of all the things He has given me, nothing has made me more unmanageable by the devil than that peace. Where he used to intimidate me, he cannot do it anymore because there is no tree for him to land in. It has died and gone out of my soul.

I believe in counselors, but I am also an advocate of praying in tongues as an inner healer. He that searches the heart knows the mind of the Spirit and can make intercession according to the will of God. He can transform the miserable creature we were into someone clothed outwardly with the nature of the inner man.

Some hurts go so deep that crisis peels off the outer layers and exposes them. Emotions can camouflage even your best efforts.

A man may decide to become a good husband and father, hold a job, and provide for his family. His emotions are high, adrenaline flows, and good intentions carry him for a while. But if the foundation is not changed, eventually he wakes up one day and cannot make himself go on.

Many people cannot rise above where they operate because they do not know how to change the power plant.

Counselors can sometimes cut off major limbs and even dig up shallow roots. But without God and the Holy Spirit, who lives where the problem is, permanent change is hard to produce.

Emotions have power. Fear can shut a body down. Phobias can make a person panic in an elevator where nothing natural is harming him. Where did that program come from? Where does it live? It lives in the soul, but it must be destroyed by transformation in the spirit.

Some have been hurt, traumatized, violated, or condemned by past sin. Every time they get ready to believe God, condemnation rises from that root and cancels them out.

The basics of prayer include edification: the Holy Spirit working in the inner man while you pray in the car, in church, and in private. You pray mysteries, and transformation takes place in the inner man. That transformation overpowers the outer man until you begin to look like Jesus.

Ephesians 4 says Christ gave apostles, prophets, evangelists, pastors, and teachers for the maturing of the saints; helps and governments for the work of the ministry; and diversities of tongues for the edifying of the body of Christ until we come into the unity of the faith.

Edification is the spiritual operation within you that causes transformation to the Word.

Ephesians says:

That ye put off concerning the former conversation the old man, which is corrupt according to the deceitful lusts;
And be renewed in the spirit of your mind;
And that ye put on the new man, which after God is created in righteousness and true holiness.

Then Paul names what must be put off:

Wherefore putting away lying, speak every man truth with his neighbour...
Be ye angry, and sin not: let not the sun go down upon your wrath:
Neither give place to the devil.

He says the thief should steal no more, but work with his hands so he can give to those in need. He says no corrupt communication should come out of our mouths, but only what edifies and ministers grace.

Then he says:

Grieve not the holy Spirit of God...

Do not refuse His work. Do not refuse His teaching.

Let bitterness, wrath, anger, clamor, evil speaking, and malice be put away. Be kind, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake has forgiven you.

Ephesians continues:

Be ye therefore followers of God, as dear children;
And walk in love, as Christ also hath loved us...

Fornication, uncleanness, covetousness, filthiness, foolish talking, and jesting are not fitting for saints. No unclean or covetous person has inheritance in the kingdom of Christ and of God. Do not let anyone deceive you with vain words.

You were once darkness, but now you are light in the Lord. Walk as children of light. The fruit of the Spirit is in all goodness, righteousness, and truth. Have no fellowship with the unfruitful works of darkness, but rather reprove them.

Paul says:

Awake thou that sleepest, and arise from the dead, and Christ shall give thee light.

If a believer lives in these works of darkness, the world can lay him beside a spiritually dead man and hardly tell the difference. So arise from the dead. Let Christ give you light.

My advice is this: do not grieve the Holy Spirit. Yield yourself to Him. Develop relationship with the Father through praying in tongues and every other manner of prayer. Worship God in private. Speak the Word. Resist sin. Destroy the roots. Circumcise yourself from the works of darkness.

Begin to walk in true holiness, and He will bless you: holiness before God, financial blessing, peace, anointing, and power. His power will develop like a power plant inside your spirit, and He will give you light.

Glory be to God forever.